



HOLY SITE: Pilgrims pay their respects at Pillar 42/7 on the Indo-Pak border

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Zero Line Pilgrimage

An unlikely site for paying homage to a gurdwara in Pakistan turns symbol of cross-border bonhomie

■ **By Ramesh Vinayak**

For the Border Security Force (BSF), it is one of the vantage points on the border, affording an expansive view of Pakistani territory. But at this border outpost, near Dera Baba Nanak town in Punjab's Gurdaspur district, civilians invariably outnumber BSF personnel for most of the day. With clasped hands, they reverentially focus their gaze, across four-and-a-half km, on a distant building rising above the horizon beyond a wire fence and yellow flags marking the border. This is the closest they can get to the historic Gurdwara Kartarpur Sahib, in Narowal district, without having to enter Pakistan.

Guru Nanak, the founder of Sikhism, spent his last 17 years at Kartarpur in the first half of the 15th century. This gurdwara has been a part of Pakistan since Partition. It re-emerged on the pilgrimage map in 1999 when the Auqaf Trust, which maintains Hindu and Sikh shrines in Pakistan, renovated it. This followed a series of discussions among some expatriate Sikhs who had mooted a proposal for building a trans-border corridor to provide easy access to Indian pilgrims. So in March this year, the BSF allowed dawn-to-dusk access to civilians up to the border post and built a *darshan sthal* (site of worship) for them.



The gurdwara is easily visible from the Indian side now that the Pakistani authorities have spruced it up with a fresh coat of paint and cleared obstructions to the view. Pillar number 42/7 has now turned into unlikely place of pilgrimage for Sikhs and stands proud as a new port of cross-border cordiality between the hostile neighbours. The place now draws devotees in droves, ranging from a daily average of 500 to 1,000 on weekends. The number swells past 5,000 on the auspicious monthly occasion of *Amavas*.

Pakistan's border security agency, the Sulej Rangers, objected at first as ground rules prohibit raising any concrete structures within 150 m of the zero line, but relented after BSF officials explained its purpose. In May, when the site was opened to the public, the head granthi of this gurdwara and the Pakistani rangers participated in the *Akhand Path* (reading of Sri Guru Granth Sahib) on the zero line.

Demands for a corridor connecting the border and the gurdwara are growing. External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee recently visited this site and expressed his hope that such a corridor would become another confidence-building measure between the two nations. Clearly, it has opened another window of cross-border bonhomie. ■